

Session 22: Reflecting on Jesus' Teaching

Key Takeaways

- Matthew highlights the response of the crowd, inviting us to examine our own response and reflect on the words we just heard.
- The astonishing authority of Jesus is a thread that runs throughout the book of Matthew.
- Jesus' teaching is not simplistic, and it invites us into a lifetime of meditation.
- Studying Scripture in community is transformative. Sharing in the perspectives of others builds us up as the Bible invites all of us to be people of God's Kingdom.

Jesus Teaches With Authority

Matthew 7:28-29 Instructor's Translation

And it came about when Jesus finished these words, the crowds were astonished at his teaching, because he was teaching as one having authority, and not like their scribes.

It Is Finished ... For Now

This is the first of five coordinated conclusions throughout the main body of Matthew's account of Jesus. Each one has been modeled after the conclusion of Moses' main speeches in Deuteronomy, and is part of a larger strategy to portray Jesus as Israel's messianic greater-than-Moses. But the conclusion to Matthew 5-7 is unique among these five conclusions, as it is the only one that does not immediately transition into the next story.

Matthew 7:28 Instructor's Translation

And it came about when Jesus **finished** (ἐτέλεσεν) these words, the crowds were astonished ...

Matthew 11:1-2 Instructor's Translation

And it came about when he **finished** (ἐτέλεσεν) instructing his twelve apprentices, he moved on from there, to teach and to announce in their cities, and Ioannes, having heard in prison about the works of the Messiah ...

Matthew 13:53-54 Instructor's Translation

And it came about when Jesus **finished** (ἐτέλεσεν) these parables, he went away from there, and having gone to his homeland, he was teaching them in their synagogue,

Matthew 19:1-2 Instructor's Translation

And it came about when Jesus **finished** (ἐτέλεσεν) these words, he went away from Galilaia, and he went into the regions of Ioudaia, beyond the Iordanes, and many crowds followed him, and he healed them there;

Matthew 26:1-2 Instructor's Translation

And it came about when Jesus **finished** (ἐτέλεσεν) all these words, he said to his apprentices, “You know that Paskha happens after two days, and the son of the human is to be handed over to be crucified.”

“Despite the significant parallels with the conclusions to the other major discourses, 7:28–9 stands out as atypical. This is because it is the only conclusion which does not carry the story forward. 11:1; 13:54; 19:1; and 26:1 all immediately immerse the reader back into the narrative flow. Only after the sermon on the mount is there a pause in which to catch one’s breath. This circumstance undoubtedly advertises the uniqueness of 5–7 for the evangelist’s work. Matthew’s readers are expected to stop and ponder what has been said; they are to realize, however dimly, that the great sermon hides a multitude of profound ramifications and that it is accordingly something to be returned to again and again.”

Davies, W. D. & Allison Jr., Dale C. (2004). [*Matthew, vol. 1 \(International Critical Commentary\)*](#). T&T Clark International. 725.

Teaching With Authority

Matthew registers the powerful effect Jesus’ teaching had on the (mainly) Israelite crowds who heard his teaching. There is a contrast with the kind of Torah-teaching they normally hear. Matthew does not tell us what exactly they heard that struck them in a new way, but he links it to the word “authority” (Greek: *exousia* / ἐξουσία).

With this word, Matthew begins a golden thread throughout his account, which will portray Jesus as having a unique, divine authority as he challenges Israel’s leaders. It is also related to the word “permitted” or, more literally, “authorized,” (Greek: *exestin* / ἔξεστιν).

Matthew 9:6-8 LEB

“But in order that you may know that **the Son of Man has authority on earth** to forgive sins,” then he said to the paralytic, “Get up, pick up your stretcher and go to your home.” And he got up and went to his home. But when the crowds saw this, they were afraid and glorified God who had given such **authority** to humans.

Matthew 10:1 LEB

And summoning his twelve disciples, he gave them **authority** over unclean spirits, so that they could expel them and could heal every disease and every sickness.

Matthew 12:2-4 Instructor's Translation

But when the Pharisees saw it, they said to him, “Behold, your disciples are doing what it is not **authorized** to do on the Sabbath!” So he said to them, “Have you not read what David did when he was hungry, and

those with him, how he entered into the house of God and ate the bread of the presentation, which it was not **authorized** for him or for those with him to eat, but only for the priests?

Matthew 21:23 LEB

And after he arrived at the temple, the chief priests and the elders of the people came up to him while he was teaching, saying, “By what **authority** are you doing these things? And who gave you this **authority**?”

Matthew 28:18 LEB

And Jesus approached and spoke to them, saying, “All **authority** in heaven and on earth has been given to me.”

There is another layer to this comment, however. In 1st century Jewish culture, where Torah-teaching was very much a communal and multi-generational endeavor, novelty was not a virtue when it came to teaching Torah in Israel. Rather, the legitimacy of a rabbi's teaching was shown by the lineage of ideas from teacher to student, as embodied in the famous saying about one of the most influential rabbis of the 1st century:

Pesakhim 6:1:33a The Jerusalem Talmud

“Rabbi Hillel lectured on the matter all day long, but they did not receive his teaching until he said, ‘Thus I heard from Shemaiah and Abtalion.’”

“Whereas scribal rulings were based on the tradition of earlier interpreters of the law, Jesus has in 5:17–48 set himself up as an authority over against that interpretive tradition, on the basis not of a formal training or authorization but of his own confident, ‘I tell you.’ It was that sort of inherent ‘authority’ that the people missed in their scribes, even though their office commanded respect. When to that remarkable claim is added Jesus’ assumption that he himself is the proper object of people’s allegiance and the arbiter of their destiny (5:11–12; 7:21–23, 24, 26), the crowd’s astonishment is hardly out of place.”

France, R. T. (2007). [*The Gospel of Matthew \(The New International Commentary on the New Testament\)*](#). Eerdmans. 299.

Reflection Question

Take some time to reflect on the insights you learned in this class.